ABEL W. SUGEBO

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SUMMARY

Trust and safety practitioner and influence operations analyst with 10+ years in information integrity, platform manipulation research, and digital rights. Founder of Ethiopia's first IFCN-accredited fact-checking platform and a certified DISARM analyst. Track record building OSINT investigations, content policy analysis, and cross-border threat research, including published research on coordinated abuse of automated content moderation and AI-generated propaganda. Native Amharic speaker with regional depth across the Horn of Africa and Red Sea information environment. Fully authorized to work in the United States.

PROFESSIONAL EXPERIENCE

Executive Director and Founder
Inform Africa / HaqCheck | Addis Ababa, Ethiopia and Remote | 2021 – Present

- Founded and lead Ethiopia's first International Fact-Checking Network (IFCN) accredited platform, directing open source intelligence (OSINT) investigations into disinformation, influence operations, and coordinated platform manipulation across the Horn of Africa and Red Sea information environment.
- Secured and maintain IFCN accreditation through annual external assessment covering methodology, transparency, funding disclosure, and corrections policy.
- Authored "When AI Moderation Becomes a Weapon: Ethiopia's Mass Reporting Crisis" (2026), an investigation documenting coordinated mass-reporting campaigns that weaponize automated content moderation to force takedowns of journalist and civil society accounts.
- Authored a DISARM case study of AI-generated propaganda linking Grand Ethiopian Renaissance Dam (GERD) narratives to "Assab" sea-access narratives (2025).
- Built and operationalized DISARM-based analytical workflows for classifying influence operation tactics, techniques, and procedures (TTPs), applied across an investigation series spanning elections, armed conflict, economic policy, and human rights.
- Built and managed a distributed team of up to 15 researchers, editors, and verification staff; own organizational budget, donor reporting, and strategy.
- Sustained continuous publication and staff safety through active armed conflict and repeated nationwide internet shutdowns.

Ethiopia Country Researcher
CIPESA (Collaboration on International ICT Policy for East and Southern Africa) | Remote | 2025 – 2026 | Consulting engagement

- Authored the Ethiopia country chapter of State of Internet Freedom in Africa for two consecutive editions, analyzing network disruptions, platform regulation, surveillance practice, and legal restrictions on digital expression.
- Delivered research to an external institution's methodology, peer review process, and publication deadlines.

Managing Director
Addis Zeybe | Addis Ababa, Ethiopia | 2018 – 2024 | Concurrent with Inform Africa from 2021

- Led editorial, operations, and strategy for an independent digital news organization of approximately 30 staff covering Ethiopian politics, armed conflict, and information integrity.
- Directed conflict-period coverage of disinformation and platform manipulation, establishing verification and sourcing standards applied across the newsroom.
- Managed editorial and operations staff with full ownership of the organizational budget and donor relationships through sustained political instability and regulatory pressure.

Consultant, Media Resilience and Digital Safety
Free Press Unlimited | Amsterdam, Netherlands (remote) | 2020 – 2022 | Concurrent with Addis Zeybe

- Advised on media resilience, information integrity, and digital safety programming for newsrooms and civil society organizations operating in high-risk and conflict-affected environments.
- Delivered assessments and training within an international NGO's program framework, reporting against defined deliverables and timelines.

Fact-Checker
PesaCheck | Nairobi, Kenya (remote) | 2020 – 2021 | Contract, concurrent with Addis Zeybe

- Investigated and debunked viral misinformation across East African information ecosystems using reverse image analysis, geolocation, account network mapping, and primary-source verification.
- Published to the editorial and methodological standards of Africa's largest fact-checking initiative.

Editor
Addis Fortune | Addis Ababa, Ethiopia | 2017 – 2018

- Edited business, economic, and public policy coverage for one of Ethiopia's leading English-language newspapers.

Mechanical Engineer
Ethiopian Airlines | Addis Ababa, Ethiopia | 2011 – 2014

- Technical systems and maintenance engineering in a safety-critical operating environment; quantitative foundation for later data-driven analytical work.

SELECTED PUBLICATIONS AND RESEARCH

- "False in 2021, Asserted in 2026: Eritrean Troops and the Politics of Verification," Inform Africa, October 2026.
- "When AI Moderation Becomes a Weapon: Ethiopia's Mass Reporting Crisis," Inform Africa, March 2026.
- "DISARM Case Study: AI-Generated Propaganda Linking GERD Pride to 'Assab' Sea-Access Narratives," Inform Africa, December 2025.
- State of Internet Freedom in Africa, Ethiopia country chapter, CIPESA, 2025 and 2026.
- "Comprehensive Training Module for Advanced Fact-Checking Using OSINT Technologies," Inform Africa, December 2025.
- "Assessing the Impact of Disinformation on Current Ethiopian Economic Reform: A Social Media Analysis," Inform Africa, December 2024.
- "Measuring Government Responsiveness in Ethiopia: Implications for Countering Disinformation," Inform Africa, September 2023.
- "Annual Report 2022: War and Disinformation," Inform Africa, March 2023.
- "Disinformation Pathways and Effects," Inform Africa with CIPESA, August 2022.
- "Report on the 6th Ethiopian General Election and Human Rights Violations," Inform Africa, February 2022.
- Contributor, DISARM Framework documentation, data-knowledge-hub.com.

SKILLS

Trust and Safety: content policy analysis and enforcement, coordinated inauthentic behavior (CIB) detection, platform manipulation analysis, content moderation systems, adversarial testing and red teaming, risk assessment and escalation

Influence Operations: DISARM framework (certified analyst), Foreign Information Manipulation and Interference (FIMI), TTP classification and attribution, narrative and network analysis, threat intelligence reporting, AI-generated propaganda analysis

OSINT and Research: open source intelligence collection, reverse image analysis, geolocation, account network mapping, fact-checking and verification methodology, qualitative and quantitative research design, OSINT training design and delivery

Technical: Python, SQL, Power BI, data analysis and visualization

Languages: Amharic (native), English (fluent)

AWARDS AND RECOGNITION

- CPJ International Press Freedom Award, Committee to Protect Journalists, 2015
- TV5 Monde Prize, 2015
- Hellman-Hammett Grant, Human Rights Watch, 2015
- Martin Ennals Award for Human Rights Defenders, Finalist, 2016

EDUCATION AND CERTIFICATION

B.S., Mechanical Engineering, Bahir Dar University, Ethiopia, 2005–2008

Certified DISARM Analyst

LEADERSHIP AND AFFILIATIONS

Co-founder, Zone Nine, Ethiopia's first independent digital rights blogging collective

Member, Global Coalition for Tech Justice